

Trying to train yourself to read a lot faster

8 findings · 13-step checklist · 1 myth · 6 sources · cheatgrid.com

Paying for training can feel like finally doing something about the pile, but reading a lot faster while still taking in what's there runs into real limits in your eyes and brain, **not a trick you haven't found yet**.

THE GOAL

You're trying to get through more of what's stacked up, **not to make reading itself faster**. Split what needs a full read from what only needs the gist.

CHECKLIST

Opening a speed-reading app or course, about to start the first lesson.

- ☐ Name what's actually stacked up right now, by title or topic, before you touch the app.
- ☐ Sort everything stacked up into two groups: what needs a full, careful read, and what only needs the gist.
- ☐ Time yourself reading two ordinary pages at your normal pace, and write down the words-per-minute.
- ☐ See where your own number falls: typical adult reading paces run from about 175 up to 300 words a minute.
- ☐ Write down how many pages a genuinely faster pace would actually save you this week.
- ☐ If it would only save you a few pages this week, close the app and go straight to whatever only needs the gist.
- ☐ If a drill tells you to stop your eyes moving back over a line, ignore it and reread the part you missed.
- ☐ If the material has you sounding words out in your head, let that continue, especially on anything dense.
- ☐ For anything you've decided just needs a skim, read each paragraph's first sentence, plus the opening and closing of the piece.
- ☐ For anything you've decided needs a full read, read it at your normal pace, with no timer, pacer or app running underneath it.
- ☐ When a quiz says you "passed" a fast read, ask whether you could explain how two of its ideas connected, not just recall a fact.
- ☐ If you can't explain how two of its ideas connected, go back over that reading at your normal pace before counting it as done.
- ☐ Before you stop for now, decide whether the next new thing you pick up needs a full read or just a skim.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 A rising words-per-minute score inside the app doesn't prove **its specific technique is what worked**.
- 2 Even in a real head-to-head test, a speed-reading app only got people reading **42 words a minute faster** than people given no training at all.
- 3 Passing a quiz right after a fast read doesn't mean **you understood it the way you normally would**.

The trade-off you're trying to avoid

KNOW

Reading much faster costs you comprehension. **Speed and understanding rise and fall together**, not separately.

Across many tests of readers trained to go faster, comprehension dropped exactly as their speed climbed. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Your normal pace is probably already fine. Most adults read somewhere around **175 to 300 words a minute**.

A review pooling 190 studies and over 18,000 readers put that range as the normal spread for English silent reading. [Source 2](#)

Why the tricks you're tempted to force backfire

DON'T

Don't train yourself to stop your eyes glancing back over a line. **That backward glance is how you catch** the part you didn't fully get the first time.

A backward glance like that moves your eyes to text you haven't fully understood yet, not text already covered. [Source 1](#)

DON'T

Don't try to silence the voice in your head that sounds words out as you read. **Blocking it competes for the same mental resources you need to understand what you're reading.**

In a test that blocked that inner voice by having people count aloud while reading, comprehension and recall got worse. [Source 3](#)

WATCH

A rising words-per-minute score inside the app doesn't prove **its specific technique is what worked**.

In a real comparison test, a plain attention-only group gained almost as much speed as the app's own technique group. [Source 4](#)

What a real result actually looks like

KNOW

Even in a real head-to-head test, a speed-reading app only got people reading **42 words a minute faster** than people given no training at all.

A 42-word gain is nowhere near the doubling or tripling these programs often promise, even though comprehension held up too. [Source 4](#)

DO

Read more of what you already read often. That's what builds a bit of real speed, **not a special app**.

People with more everyday reading practice recognized words faster and more accurately in lab word-recognition tests. [Source 5](#)

KNOW

Passing a quiz right after a fast read doesn't mean **you understood it the way you normally would**.

Trained fast readers showed no sign, in reaction-time tests, that they'd picked up the connections a passage was building between its ideas. [Source 6](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

A speed-reading app or course can teach you to read a lot faster and understand it just as well, or even better, than you do now.

ACTUALLY

Tests on trained speed and skim readers found no real sign they picked up the connections between ideas that a normal-paced reader catches. **Faster can cost you understanding, not add to it.** [Source 6](#)

Sources

1. https://www.psychologicalscience.org/publications/speed_reading.html
2. <https://biblio.ugent.be/publication/8647789>
3. <https://eric.ed.gov/?id=EJ481168>
4. <https://d-nb.info/1365425681/34>

5. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC8385780/>

6. <https://scholars.nova.edu/en/publications/the-impact-of-reading-at-rapid-rates-on-inference-generation-2/>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Reading more and reading well at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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